Perseverant Digital
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A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL

The AI Answer Audit

Find out what ChatGPT, Google AI Mode, Perplexity, Claude and Gemini say when a prospect asks who to hire in your market, and what to fix first.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 61 WORDS REVIEWED OCTOBER 15, 20

AI assistants tend to recommend the businesses they can read, understand and verify. If a competitor gets named and you don't, the usual causes are pages crawle can't see, inconsistent business details, no direct answers to buyer questions, thin reviews or few outside mentions. Run your buyers' real questions through each assistant, score the answers, then fix those fundamentals in order.

Why does this matter now?

Prospects now ask AI assistants who to hire, and the answer often names two or three business and stops. If you are not one of them, you never hear about the question.

Google says AI Mode passed 1 billion monthly users (Sundar Pichai, Alphabet Q2 2026 earnings remarks, July 22, 2026). In BrightLocal's 2026 survey of 1,002 US adults, use of ChatGPT and oth AI tools for local recommendations rose from 6% to 45% (BrightLocal, a local marketing software vendor, February 11, 2026).

The old click is shrinking. Pew Research Center found Google users clicked a traditional result on 8% of visits when an AI summary appeared, versus 15% without one (Pew, July 22, 2025). Being cited still helps: Seer Interactive, a marketing agency, found brands cited in an AI Overview earned 35% more organic clicks than brands not cited (Seer Interactive, November 4 2025).

Ranking a link is no longer the whole job. You also need to be the name inside the answer.

What this looks like for your business

The pattern holds in most service businesses. A buyer describes a problem in plain words, the assistant explains it, then names a few businesses. Your audit checks both: whether the explanation is accurate, and whether you are one of the names.

Step 1: What questions should you test?

Test the questions a buyer types right before they call, not the keywords you rank for. Write 12 prompts in plain language, with your city or a real situation in each.

Prompt type	Template	How many	Your versions
Who to hire	Who should I hire for [service] in [city]?	3	
Cost	How much does [service] cost in [city], and what drives the price?	2	
How to choose	What should I ask a [business type] before I hire them?	3	
Comparison	[Your business] vs [top competitor] for [situation]?	2	
Name check	What do you know about [your business] in [city]? Any concerns?	2	

Example prompts:

- “My roof is leaking after the storm. Who do I call in Parma?”
- “How much do dental implants cost in Columbus?”
- “Which staffing firms place CNC machinists in Northeast Ohio?”
- “What questions should I ask before hiring a [business type]?”

Step 2: How do you run and score the prompts?

Run each prompt from a clean session, in each assistant, twice, and score every answer the sar way. Your own history and location shape what you see, and answers vary between runs.

- [ ] Private window, logged out, or memory and personalization turned off
- [ ] City named in the prompt, not left to the browser
- [ ] ChatGPT, Google AI Mode, Perplexity, Claude and Gemini, web search on
- [ ] Every prompt run twice, with the text and date saved
- [ ] No client, patient or case details in any prompt

Prompt #	Assistant	Run	Named?	Position	Linked to you?	Accurate? (note errors)	Competitors named	Sources cited
1	ChatGPT	1						

Mention rate = answers naming you ÷ total answers scored. Do the same for your top two competitors.

Example numbers, not benchmarks: 120 answers (12 prompts, 5 assistants, 2 runs), named in 1 is a 15% mention rate. A competitor named in 54 is at 45%.

The sources column matters most. It shows which directories, review sites and publications th assistants trust in your market. Those are the places you need to be.

Step 3: Can AI crawlers actually read your site?

Check this before you write a new page. If crawlers cannot see your content, nothing else show up in their answers. Vercel found that none of the major AI crawlers, including GPTBot, ClaudeBot and PerplexityBot, render JavaScript; Gemini uses Googlebot's infrastructure and does (Vercel, December 17, 2024).

- [ ] "View page source" (not "Inspect") on your homepage and a key service page shows your main text, phone and address
- [ ] yoursite.com/robots.txt has no `Disallow` lines blocking OAI-SearchBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, Googlebot or Bingbot
- [ ] Site verified and sitemap submitted in Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools

OpenAI says sites that block OAI-SearchBot will not be shown in ChatGPT search answers, and that GPTBot, its training crawler, is controlled separately (OpenAI crawler documentation). You can block training and still allow search. Make that a deliberate choice, not an accident from a old plugin.

Step 4: What should you fix first?

Fix fundamentals before buying any tool. We call this Search Essence Optimization: people search to understand a business, not just find it, and assistants work the same way. Meet them the middle with one clear, consistent story.

Start with one sentence and use it everywhere: **[Business name] is a [business type] in [city or region] that helps [who] with [what problem], known for [one specific, verifiable difference].**

- [ ] **Consistent details.** Match name, address and phone across your site, Google Business Profile, Bing Places, Apple Business Connect and directories. Fix every error from your accura column.

- [ ] **One page per real question.** Turn your weakest prompts into pages with a 40–70 word dire answer at the top.
- [ ] **Schema.** Organization or LocalBusiness markup, plus Person markup for owners, identica to the page.
- [ ] **Reviews.** Ask every satisfied customer and reply in your own words. BrightLocal found 47 of consumers won't use a business with fewer than 20 reviews (BrightLocal, February 11, 2026) Never buy, fake or filter reviews; the FTC's 2024 rule bans them (Morgan Lewis, August 26, 2024
- [ ] **Outside mentions.** Get listed or quoted on the sites in your sources column.

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **One audit is a snapshot.** Answers change from run to run and week to week. A real picture takes repeated sampling across assistants, which is hard to keep up by hand.

> **Earning outside mentions.** Knowing which publications matter is the easy part. Getting featured takes relationships, pitches and content those editors want.

> **Doing it every month.** The audit only pays off if you rerun it, compare results and keep fixing. Many owners run it once, then the business takes over.

If you want help with the last stretch, book a 25-minute exploration call using the short form at the end of this guide.

Sources

- Alphabet, "Alphabet Q2 2026 earnings remarks" (Sundar Pichai), July 22, 2026. link
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- Vercel, "The rise of the AI crawler," December 17, 2024. link
- OpenAI, "Overview of OpenAI crawlers," accessed October 15, 2026. link
- Morgan Lewis, "FTC issues final rule on consumer reviews and testimonials," August 26, 202 link

Want a second set of eyes on what you found?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your answers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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